

In a Mood

"It really doesn't count if it's with dinner, you know," she says.

"Wine counts wherever you drink it," I argue.

"Yes, but wine with dinner is like coffee in the morning."

White linen, three candles assorted, empty glasses standing tall. She has the wine menu against the table, flipping the dozens of pages. I have the regular menu flat in my lap. It's only one page but my head is turned towards the glass watching the rain pour down against the cars parked outside.

"I say we do a red to start then we can switch to a white and take the bottle with us," she says.

"I really don't feel like drinking."

"Well what, your going to make me drink alone?"

"I'm not making you do anything."

"Jesus Christ, you always do this," she says closing the wine menu.

"What, really, here?"

"No, relax, I'm just saying you get in these moods," she tries to go on but the waiter comes. I let her order for us in French. The waiter leaves and she hunches over the table like she's about to tell a secret.

"You set your mind to something for like three weeks and drag everyone down with you."

"That's completely unfair."

"Really? Are genuinely being serious right now."

"I'm tell you don't start this."

She waves a hand. "You tell me: 'Rachel, I'd like to start waking up early.' I think oh! That sounds nice—"

"—Rachel, please—"

"—Yeah no worries, I know I work late every night to send our children to college but no, you go ahead and start waking up at 4:30 so you can: 'write at the prime of the day.' Whatever the fuck that means. And, of course, being the good supportive fucking wife I am, 'Sure, darling,' I say, 'if you think it would be good for you.' And then what do you do?"

I don't say anything.

"Go ahead, tell me what you did," she says.

"Rachel, please."

"Say it, Cooper."

"Did somebody order a red!" The sommelier comes, beaming a smile and spilling all the secret notes embodying the wine. When she asks me if I'd like a glass, I nod.

We drink the wine without talking. While we wait for the food, I listen to the conversation from the table behind me. Rachel decides she needs to use the restaurant's phone to make several calls.

The conversation behind me moves from an inquisitive take on railroad policy to the dullities of California bark. I get up and look around the restaurant. I see the waiter coming to our table with our food and Rachel turned into the phone across the room. The waiter stops and looks at me, holding two plates of bolognaise.

"Oh, I'll take that, thanks," I say.

Confused, she hands the plate to me and standing up I take a bite.

"Yumbo!" I say. "Deliciouso!"

The waiter tries a laugh but it comes as a wince. She places the other plate across from me and scurries off.

I take Rachel's wine and dump it on her pasta. Then I leave the restaurant with my plate in hand. It steams in the cold under the awning. Cars drive by kicking up rain onto my shoes. The valet looks at me holding the plate.

"Sir, I don't think you can—"

"I will fucking kill you if you keep speaking."

He stops, the kind boy, and I hail a taxi.

I slide in the back and rest the plate on my thighs. It's hot on the bottom and burns my legs. The driver peers into the mirror.

"Where to?" he asks.

"Wendy's!" I say.

The taxi takes me down the street to Wendy's. I pay with cash then slide out the back. It's pouring now and the plate is starting to accumulate water. I hunch over and rush inside the Wendy's. It's empty save for a scrawny boy at the register. I ask him for a plastic fork which he drills into my pasta.

I sit down at a window and begin to eat, watching the rain shower on the city, on its people, on the cars, the lights, the umbrellas, the rush, the traffic, hope, desire, pain, filth.